

SLOTHS AND ANTEATERS

Although very different in form and habits, sloths and anteaters have one characteristic in common: they share a lack of normal mammalian dentition.

With just one exception, members of this order, the Pilosa, are largely arboreal creatures: only the giant anteater is terrestrial. They are all native to Central and South America.

The two anteater families feed on ants, termites, and other insects. Anteaters have no teeth at all, relying on their long sticky tongue to capture insects, which are then crushed in the mouth before being swallowed.

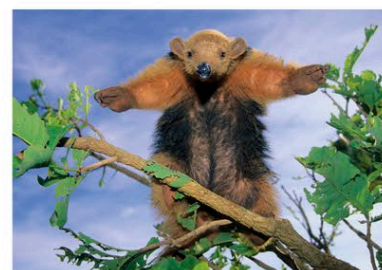
The slow-moving sloths are herbivorous. They have no incisors or canines, but instead have a number of cylindrical, rootless teeth, used to

grind up their food. A sloth may take about a month to completely digest a meal, as the fibrous leaf matter passes slowly through several stomach compartments and is broken down by bacteria.

ARBOREAL LIFE

The long, prehensile tail of the arboreal anteaters allows them to lead a more active lifestyle than the sloths. On the ground, all the arboreal species move only with difficulty, although some are excellent swimmers. When walking, their mobility is restricted by their enlarged, curved claws, which the sloths use like hooks to hang from branches. Anteaters have enlarged claws only on their front feet. These claws are used to tear open insect nests in search of food, and are formidable defence weapons.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	MAMMALIA
ORDER	PILOSA
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	16



To defend themselves members of the genus *Tamandua* stand up on their hind legs and lash out with their powerful front limbs.

THREE-TOED SLOTHS

Generally smaller and slower moving than two-toed sloths, the arboreal and mostly nocturnal Bradypodidae have three toes on each foot, bearing long, curved claws that help them to hang from branches. Their long, shaggy fur has a green tinge, due to algae growing on it.

MANED SLOTH

Bradypus torquatus

This small Brazilian sloth has long, dark fur – especially around its head and neck – which often harbours algae, ticks, and moths.



59–72 cm
23–28 in

BROWN-THROATED SLOTH

Bradypus variegatus

An inhabitant of the forests of C. and S. America, this sloth is the most widespread in its family. The female attracts her mate with a shrill scream.

52–54 cm
20½–21½ in

45–76 cm
18–30 in



shaggy,
coarse coat

PALE-THROATED SLOTH

Bradypus tridactylus

Found in the rainforests of S. America, this species usually lives alone and may rest for more than 18 hours a day.



TWO-TOED SLOTHS

Unlike three-toed sloths, the Megalonychidae have only two toes on their forefeet, a more prominent snout, and no tail. Similarly arboreal and mainly nocturnal, they usually descend from trees head first.



two toes on
front feet

54–88 cm
21½–35 in

SOUTHERN TWO-TOED SLOTH

Choloepus didactylus

This large herbivore from S. America swims well, even crossing rivers. Its main predators are large raptors, such as harpy eagles.

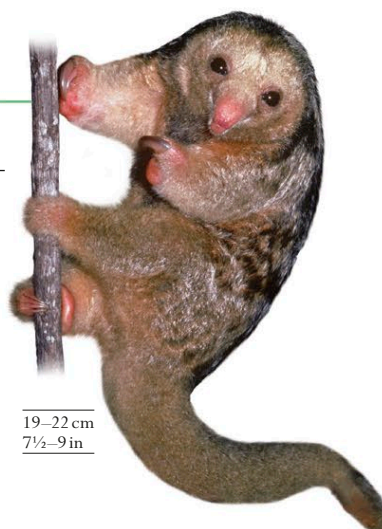


54–88 cm
21½–35 in

LINNAEUS'S TWO-TOED SLOTH

Choloepus hoffmanni

This solitary, S. American herbivore is found in the tropical forests of the Orinoco and Amazon river basins, where it spends most of its time sleeping or resting in the forest canopy.



19–22 cm
7½–9 in

SILKY ANTEATERS

The Cyclopedidae, though well-represented in the fossil record, has seven extant species. Large, curved front claws and a prehensile tail help silky anteaters live on trees, where they nest in holes. They feed on ants and termites.

SILKY ANTEATER

Cyclopes sp.

Arboreal, nocturnal, and slow moving, silky anteaters live in forested areas of Central and South America. Their claws provide an effective defence when threatened by predators.